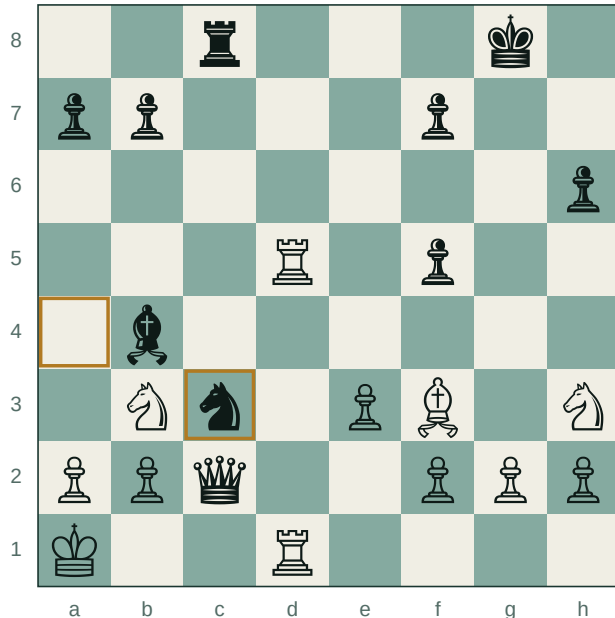


Trapping a piece: White, move 29

Trapping a piece

White to move



Previous move: 28...Nc3. Gold borders mark its start and finish.

WORKED CONTINUATION - COVER THIS SECTION FIRST

29. R5d2 Nxd1 30. Rxc2 Rxc2 31. Bxd1

29.R5d2 The rook moves from d5 to d2. Recorded reply: **29...Nxd1**.

30.Rxc2 The rook captures the queen on c2. Recorded reply: **30...Rxc2**.

31.Bxd1 The bishop captures the knight on d1.

At the end, nominal material is White 15 / Black 13 (P=1, N/B=3, R=5, Q=9). Over this line, White's balance changes by +2. Activity and king safety still affect the evaluation.

CHECKPOINT

Using P=1, N/B=3, R=5, Q=9, how much does White's material balance change over the complete line? **Answer:** +2: the balance goes from +0 to +2. Count promotions and every recapture, not just the first gain.

CARRY THE IDEA INTO YOUR GAMES

An attacked piece is not trapped if it can give check, trade itself favorably, or open an escape through a sacrifice.

WHAT THIS POSITION TEACHES

A trapped piece lacks safe retreat squares. Winning it usually requires restricting its routes before attacking it, or forcing it into a cage.

HOW TO LOOK

Trace every plausible escape square for the target, including captures and counterchecks. Then find the move that closes the remaining route.

The defending king is on g8. Geometrically undefended: rook on c8 and bishop on b4. Check for tactical protection.